

TB Spectral Transient Shaper

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Overview

Separates attack and sustain so you can change punch, clarity, and length by frequency area.

What this plug-in solves

Broadband transient shapers treat the entire signal as one envelope, so adding punch to a kick may also exaggerate cymbals or room noise. TB Spectral Transient Shaper detects attack and sustain across individual spectral bins and allows the sensitivity curve to remain global or become frequency dependent.

What you can expect

- Frequency-dependent attack enhancement or suppression
- Independent sustain shaping
- Delta monitoring of detected and changed material
- Optional saturation, clipping, oversampling, and peak limiting

How it works

TB Spectral Transient Shaper separates the start of a sound from the energy that continues after it. It can then emphasize or reduce attack and sustain in different tonal areas, allowing a drum to become punchier without making its ring louder, or a pad to become shorter without dulling its opening.

Simple Mode provides broad attack and sustain shaping. EQ Mode adds low, mid, and high focus controls so the detector can react differently across the spectrum. Monitoring helps identify what is being selected, and the saturation, clipper, and limiter stages can add density or peak control after the shape is established.

Quick start

- 1 Start in Simple Mode with Saturation, Clipper, and Limiter off.
- 2 Lower Attack Sensitivity until desired hits react, then set Attack Gain.
- 3 Lower Sustain Sensitivity until body or tails react, then set Sustain Gain.

- 4 Tune both Release controls.
- 5 Switch to EQ Mode only when the reaction must be frequency selective.
- 6 Use Monitor modes to confirm the target.
- 7 Add finishing stages last and level-match Input/Output.

Interface and key sections



This is a direct capture of the current plug-in interface. Use the visible labels to locate the areas and controls explained below.

Attack and Sustain

Attack Gain changes fast-rising energy; Sustain Gain changes stable or decaying energy. Their independent Sensitivity and Release controls determine eligibility and recovery.

Simple Mode

One horizontal sensitivity value applies across the whole spectrum for Attack and another for Sustain. It is the fastest way to establish whether the process fits the source.

EQ Mode

Independent Low, Mid, and High frequency, Q, and sensitivity nodes build frequency-dependent detector curves for Attack and Sustain.

Monitor modes

Normal, Normal Delta, Attack, Attack Delta, Sustain, and Sustain Delta reveal either the full result or the material identified/changed by a particular detector.

Saturation

Enable Saturation, choose Soft, Punch, Warm, Digital, Fold, or Hard, set Drive, and optionally link the shaper behavior through Saturation Shaper Link.

Clipper and Limiter

Clipper uses its own threshold for hard peak shaping. Limiter uses Limiter Threshold and the Lookahead control. They are separate final safety/character stages.

Oversampling

x1, x2, x4, or x8 affects the non-linear finishing stages and CPU/latency tradeoff. Choose higher factors when distortion quality matters.

Controllable properties

The guide uses the names shown on the plug-in panel. Each explanation describes the audible result, a useful way to approach the control, and an important interaction to listen for.

Control	What it does and when to use it
ATK_HIGH Frequency	Chooses the tonal area used for attack shaping in this band. Sweep broadly to find the useful tonal area, then make the focus narrower and the change smaller while listening in the full mix.
ATK_HIGH Q	Sets how wide or narrow this band's attack focus is. Sweep broadly to find the useful tonal area, then make the focus narrower and the change smaller while listening in the full mix.
ATK_HIGH Sensitivity	Sets how easily attack energy is selected in this band. Move it until the section reacts too often, then back away until it follows only the events you actually want to control.
ATK_LOW Frequency	Chooses the tonal area used for attack shaping in this band. Sweep broadly to find the useful tonal area, then make the focus narrower and the change smaller while listening in the full mix.
ATK_LOW Q	Sets how wide or narrow this band's attack focus is. Sweep broadly to find the useful tonal area, then make the focus narrower and the change smaller while listening in the full mix.
ATK_LOW Sensitivity	Sets how easily attack energy is selected in this band. Move it until the section reacts too often, then back away until it follows only the events you actually want to control.
ATK_MID Frequency	Chooses the tonal area used for attack shaping in this band. Sweep broadly to find the useful tonal area, then make the focus narrower and the change smaller while listening in the full mix.
ATK_MID Q	Sets how wide or narrow this band's attack focus is. Sweep broadly to find the useful tonal area, then make the focus narrower and the change smaller while listening in the full mix.
ATK_MID Sensitivity	Sets how easily attack energy is selected in this band. Move it until the section reacts too often, then back away until it follows only the events you actually want to control.

Control	What it does and when to use it
Attack Gain	Raises or lowers the front edge of sounds. Judge this control while the source repeats in the full arrangement. The right timing should support the groove without making the sound feel detached.
Attack Release	Sets how quickly attack shaping relaxes after each hit. Judge this control while the source repeats in the full arrangement. The right timing should support the groove without making the sound feel detached.
Attack Sensitivity	Sets how easily the plug-in identifies attack energy. Move it until the section reacts too often, then back away until it follows only the events you actually want to control.
Bypass	Turns the complete effect off or on for a direct before-and-after comparison. Compare with bypass at a similar loudness. If the effect creates a tail, let that tail settle before judging the difference.
Clipper	Turns on firm peak trimming before the final output. Level-match the result and listen for lost transients or harsh buildup. More color is useful only while the source still keeps its role in the mix.
Clipper Threshold	Sets the level where the clipper begins trimming peaks. Move it until the section reacts too often, then back away until it follows only the events you actually want to control.
Input Gain	Sets how loud the sound enters the plug-in. Raise it for a stronger response or lower it for more headroom. Match the final loudness before deciding whether the processing sounds better. Extra level can make almost any setting seem more impressive.
Limiter	Turns on final peak protection. Level-match the result and listen for lost transients or harsh buildup. More color is useful only while the source still keeps its role in the mix.
Limiter Threshold	Sets the maximum level allowed by the limiter. Move it until the section reacts too often, then back away until it follows only the events you actually want to control.
Lookahead	Helps catch sudden peaks more smoothly. Higher values can feel slightly less immediate. Judge this control while the source repeats in the full arrangement. The right timing should support the groove without making the sound feel detached.

Control	What it does and when to use it
Mode	Chooses one broad control pair or separate low, mid, and high sensitivity controls. Compare the available characters on the same short passage. Choose by the musical result rather than by the name of the mode.
Monitor	Chooses the full result or isolates the attack, sustain, or removed difference for listening. Move it gradually and listen for the point where the intended result becomes clear without introducing a new problem elsewhere.
Output Gain	Sets the final listening level after processing. Match the final loudness before deciding whether the processing sounds better. Extra level can make almost any setting seem more impressive.
Oversampling	Makes heavy distortion or limiting sound cleaner at the cost of more CPU use. Move it gradually and listen for the point where the intended result becomes clear without introducing a new problem elsewhere.
Program	Loads a factory starting point. Adjust the controls afterward to fit the current sound. Use a preset as a direction, not a finished answer. Change one section at a time so it is clear which adjustment improves the source.
Saturation	Sets how strongly this part controls level after the threshold. Level-match the result and listen for lost transients or harsh buildup. More color is useful only while the source still keeps its role in the mix.
Saturation Drive	Sets how strongly this part controls level after the threshold. Level-match the result and listen for lost transients or harsh buildup. More color is useful only while the source still keeps its role in the mix.
Saturation Mode	Chooses the harmonic character added to the shaped sound. Level-match the result and listen for lost transients or harsh buildup. More color is useful only while the source still keeps its role in the mix.
Saturation Shaper Link	Makes the saturation follow the current attack and sustain shaping. Level-match the result and listen for lost transients or harsh buildup. More color is useful only while the source still keeps its role in the mix.
SUS_HIGH Frequency	Chooses the tonal area used for sustain shaping in this band. Sweep broadly to find the useful tonal area, then make the focus narrower and the change smaller while listening in the full mix.

Control	What it does and when to use it
SUS_HIGH Q	Sets how wide or narrow this band's sustain focus is. Sweep broadly to find the useful tonal area, then make the focus narrower and the change smaller while listening in the full mix.
SUS_HIGH Sensitivity	Sets how easily sustain energy is selected in this band. Move it until the section reacts too often, then back away until it follows only the events you actually want to control.
SUS_LOW Frequency	Chooses the tonal area used for sustain shaping in this band. Sweep broadly to find the useful tonal area, then make the focus narrower and the change smaller while listening in the full mix.
SUS_LOW Q	Sets how wide or narrow this band's sustain focus is. Sweep broadly to find the useful tonal area, then make the focus narrower and the change smaller while listening in the full mix.
SUS_LOW Sensitivity	Sets how easily sustain energy is selected in this band. Move it until the section reacts too often, then back away until it follows only the events you actually want to control.
SUS_MID Frequency	Chooses the tonal area used for sustain shaping in this band. Sweep broadly to find the useful tonal area, then make the focus narrower and the change smaller while listening in the full mix.
SUS_MID Q	Sets how wide or narrow this band's sustain focus is. Sweep broadly to find the useful tonal area, then make the focus narrower and the change smaller while listening in the full mix.
SUS_MID Sensitivity	Sets how easily sustain energy is selected in this band. Move it until the section reacts too often, then back away until it follows only the events you actually want to control.
Sustain Gain	Raises or lowers the body and tail of sounds. Raise it until the contribution is obvious, then reduce it slightly and recheck the sound in the complete mix.
Sustain Release	Sets how quickly sustain shaping returns after the sound changes. Set it in relation to the rhythm and the space between events. Listen for pumping, gaps, or a tail that covers the next sound.

Control	What it does and when to use it
Sustain Sensitivity	Sets how easily the plug-in identifies sustain energy. Move it until the section reacts too often, then back away until it follows only the events you actually want to control.

Practical uses

Tighter drum room

- Reduce Sustain Gain.
- Set Sustain Sensitivity to catch the room tail.
- Use EQ Mode to leave low sustain intact if needed.
- Monitor Sustain Delta to confirm what is removed.

Expected result: Room decay shortens while the direct hit remains focused.

More kick punch

- Raise Attack Gain.
- In EQ Mode focus Attack Low/Mid sensitivity around the kick impact.
- Use a short-to-medium Attack Release.
- Enable the limiter only if peaks need control.

Expected result: Impact increases in the intended band without equally lifting cymbals.

Common pitfalls

Focused frequency processing adds latency and can soften very sharp detail at aggressive settings. Use the lighter quality setting while recording and reserve the heavier option for playback or export. Change latency-related modes while playback is stopped.

Monitor modes are diagnostic and must be returned to Normal. Move the control more slowly or make the change between phrases. Sudden changes to time, pitch, mode, or routing can become an audible effect of their own.

Clipper and Limiter can conceal excessive transient gain; set the shaper first. Enable only the repair section that matches the problem and use the smallest amount that makes the noise less distracting without removing useful detail.